

What does a normal day look like?

Know what normal looks like. Notice when it changes.

A normal morning

Awake by

Out of the bedroom by

Breakfast around

First thing they do

A normal day

Lunch around

Naps?

Out of the house on

Sneaks to most days

A normal evening

Dinner around

In bed by

The evening usually looks like

Up in the night?

A normal week

Days that are different, and why

Who comes to the house, and when

The phone

Usually answers between

Rarely during

The phone lives

For them, this would not be normal

Not "a fall". Things that would actually be out of character: no answer by lunchtime two days running. Missing Friday prayers. Not calling back at all.

How to use this sheet

Fill it in on a good week. A baseline written during a bad month records the bad month. If they've just come out of hospital, wait until things have settled and write down what settled looks like.

Fill it in with them if they'll have it. Most parents are fine with this one, because it isn't a list of things they can't do any more. It's a description of their life, and they are the expert on it. If they'd rather not, fill it in from what you already know and don't make it a negotiation.

One different day is a different day. People go out, sleep badly, skip lunch. What this sheet is for is the second week of something, not the first afternoon of it.

Give it to whoever might need it. A sibling who visits twice a year, the neighbor with the spare key, whoever would answer the phone if you couldn't. The sheet is worth the paper it's on only if the person who needs to know what usual looks like has seen it.

Write the date, and rewrite it once a year. Normal moves. A baseline from three years ago will tell you something has changed when what actually changed was three years passing.

The last box does the work. Everything above it is description. Those four lines are the ones that turn "I have a feeling something's off" into a sentence you can act on, and the one to read first when you have that feeling.

Date filled in